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Diplomacy

Most Americans know of the Battle of New Orleans from their study of American history not only because it was a major victory over the British during the War of 1812, but also because the battle was unnecessary. The war had ended on December 24, 1814, after the British and the Americans signed what became known as the Treaty of Ghent in Belgium. The battle took place on January 8, 1815. The reason that for the continued fighting was of course the distance between Belgium and the United States and the time that it took to carry news between the two nations.

What is little known is the fact that with an increase in the speed of communications—this time between London and Washington—there is a great possibility that the War of 1812 would never have occurred. Of the list of the causes of the war, one of the most important was the “Orders in Council.” The orders were a series of regulations that required Americans trading with Continental Europe to stop at Britain first, receive British permission to proceed, and pay a fee. Americans believed that the order was aimed at destroying its mercantile prosperity, and viewed it as Britain’s attempted continuation of America’s colonial status a generation after the Revolution.

While the Orders were a problem for the United States, they also had a deleterious effect on Great Britain because the United States Congress had passed a Non-intercourse Bill which produced a damaging boycott of British goods, leading to an economic depression in Britain.

On June 16, 1812, one day before the U.S. Senate passed the war bill, and two days before President James Madison signed it, Viscount Castlereagh, the British foreign secretary, introduced into Parliament a motion calling for the repeal of the Orders. He announced “that a proposition should be made to the American government to suspend immediately the Orders in Council, on condition that they would suspend their Non-intercourse Act.” The revocation of the Orders brought rejoicing throughout Britain; it seemed that the American market would soon be open again to British goods. Instead, to their horror, British industrialists and workers learned six weeks after Castlereagh’s announcement that the repeal had been too late; the United States had declared war. Ships carrying the British concession had crossed others carrying news of war.¹

Many scholars have argued that a telegraph cable across the Atlantic would have allowed Americans to learn of Castlereagh's revocation of the Orders in time to prevent the War of 1812. In fact, twenty years later President Madison contended that if Britain had rescinded the Orders a few weeks earlier, "war would not have been at the time declared, nor is it probable that it would have followed, because there was every prospect that the affair of impressment + other grievances might have been reconciled after the repeal of the obnoxious orders in council."²

The lack of speed in long-distance communications³ was not a new problem. The tempo of domestic politics had often exceeded that of international politics. Why were the consequences so disastrous? The answer has to do with the solutions that statesmen found to the difficulties of coordinating foreign policy across great distances in the age before electric communication. In general, foreign ministers compensated for slow communication by giving diplomats greater autonomy. This autonomy, once the telegraph was in use, began to diminish when foreign ministries began to oversee and direct the activities more easily. Diplomats had mixed feelings about the encroaching power of foreign ministries. Some bridled at efforts to centralize control over foreign policy. Many appreciated increased guidance. One example concerned the American minister to France, Richard Rush. On February 24, 1848, Rush reported to Washington via ship that revolutionaries had toppled King Louis Philippe's regime and erected a republic in its stead. Rush was immediately asked by the new government to recognize it in his capacity as the American minister. Rush was weeks away from his superiors. He felt acutely isolated as he faced what he saw as a momentous decision. On the one hand, the U.S. government had specifically accredited Rush to the French court. He possessed no official status vis-à-vis the revolutionaries. On the other hand, the maintenance of good relations with the de facto government of France was the main goal of Rush's mission.

On February 28, 1848, he unilaterally recognized the new regime. Justifying his action afterward to the secretary of state, he contended: "In recognizing the new state of things, as far as I could without your instructions, and in doing it promptly ... I had the deep conviction that I was stepping forth in aid of the great cause of order in France and beyond France—and that I was acting in the spirit of my government and country, the interpreter of whose voice it fell upon me suddenly to become. If I erred, I must hope that the motives which swayed me will be my shield. The provisional government needed all the moral support obtainable.... In such an exigency, hours, moments were important."⁴

Even as Rush pondered his response to the 1848 French Revolution, technological changes were bringing closer to realization the possibility of electric communication across the Atlantic Ocean.

Among these changes, two deserve special attention: the steamship and gutta-percha. The first scheduled steamship lines crossed the Atlantic in 1838. Steamships, unlike vessels under sail, could reliably lay cable in a straight line at a controlled rate. Gutta-percha, a rubbery substance obtained from the gum of gutta trees, was used to insulate and protect the copper core of the cable. With these advancements, a cable was laid connecting the United States and Europe in 1866.

By 1870 there were three underwater telegraph cables spanning the Atlantic Ocean when Elihu B. Washburne, the U.S. minister to France, witnessed the next French revolution. On September 5, Washburne reported by telegraph from Paris that a republic had been proclaimed and asked his superiors for instructions. The next day, Acting Secretary of State J.C.B. Davis cabled that Washburne should “not hesitate to recognize” the provisional government as soon as it appeared to be the de facto source of authority.⁵ Washburne officially recognized the Third Republic one day later on September 7, 1870.

At first glance the American responses to the 1848 and 1870 revolutions suggest that the Atlantic cable had only beneficial effects on the conduct of U.S. foreign policy. Washburne, like Rush, knew that he was implementing the wishes of his superiors. The State Department could respond much more quickly during the 1870 uprising than it had in 1848. Just as important, the Atlantic cable freed policymakers from the vagaries of transatlantic steamers. The shipping schedules caused American diplomacy to become a system composed of long waits punctuated by hurried responses so that the return message would make the next boat. After waiting weeks to hear about the outcome of the 1848 revolution in France, when Rush’s message arrived, President Polk hurriedly called a cabinet meeting to discuss the events in order to send Rush instructions by the next steamer. At times, the president abruptly ended his letters with such phrases as “I cannot add more and save the mail.”⁶

Obviously, the telegraph shifted control over foreign policy from the local minister to the policymakers in Washington. Rush’s distance from the Secretary of State gave him autonomy and seemed almost to necessitate decisive action when faced with an immediate decision. In such a circumstance, a rapid communications capability changes who makes the decision. As an example, on January 14, 1848, Rush reported the death of the king’s sister. The message reached Washington a month later. President Polk sent his condolences in a letter addressed to his “great and good friend,” King Louis Philippe. By the time it reached Paris on February 29, the king had been overthrown. Rush decided to suppress the message from Polk since he was pursuing a policy of support for the new regime. By contrast, in 1870, the Prussian ambassador to France asked Wickham Hoffman, the secretary to the U.S. delegation in Paris, to assume protection of the North Germans in France during the Franco-Prussian War. Hoffman,

then leading the legation in Washburne's absence, felt that this offer served the interests of the United States and believed that his government would respond favorably. However, he could not give the Prussian ambassador an answer. His reason, as he stated later, "If there were no cable across the Atlantic, and it was necessary to say 'Yes' or 'No' at once, I should say 'Yes'; but as there was telegraphic communication, and I could receive an answer in forty-eight hours. I must ask instructions from [the secretary of state]."⁷

As these examples show, the telegraph reduced the latitude that foreign ministers had over their actions and in some cases slowed the execution of U.S. policy by diminishing individual initiative. The reduced autonomy of American diplomats stationed in Paris deviates from generalizations made about the telegraph's influence on communications within late nineteenth century European colonial empires. The historian Daniel Headrick argues that the telegraph initially did not increase the control of the central government over imperial agents. While he was referring to a nation and its colonies, his point also applies to a situation in which a nation is in communication with one of its foreign ministers:

The impact of the telegraph on colonial power relations is ambiguous, however. As the expansion of telegraphy coincided with the new imperialism, uncertainty on the frontiers of empire, ambitious imperial agents, a lack of information, and an overwhelmed central administration combined to enhance the power of the men on the spot at the expense of their home governments. But this was a temporary phenomenon associated with the phase of warfare and expansion. As soon as areas were pacified (or both the home government and its ministers became used to the telegraph), bureaucratic controls replaced the free-wheeling agents of the frontier period. And inevitably the controls operated through the telegraph wires and cables. After the turn of the century, one no longer hears much about independent proconsuls.⁸

There was also the question of having a variety of sources of information. In the instance of a colonial situation, the local representative could monopolize their end of what was generally a single telegraph line, enabling them to supervise the outgoing information that otherwise might have allowed their superiors to question and challenge their judgment. In contrast, if the situation concerned the information flow between a country and its representative to another developed nation, the foreign minister had no hope of gaining similar control over the communication because of the activities of journalists, businesspeople, and non-American diplomats with access to the same cables.

By the late nineteenth century, as an example, too many channels of communication connected the United States and Europe for a diplomat to gain a free hand because of the ignorance of his superiors about the situation involving the diplomat. The only answer that a diplomat had was to be the only “official” voice in a situation. In this circumstance, the chief foreign minister could monitor and control the sending or reception of messages at his end of the line. More than that, the cost, secrecy, and aura of importance surrounding telegrams made foreign policy officials anxious to prevent those outside the embassy from gaining information, and to limit the use of the telegraph to high-ranking bureaucrats. In 1875 the U.S. secretary of state decreed: “No messages are to be sent by the telegraph except those from the Secretary, or one of the Assistant Secretaries, or the chief Clerk, or those authorized to be sent by one of the above. Any Chief of Bureau or Clerk wishing to transmit any message on public business, by the telegraph can do so by obtaining the endorsement of the chief clerk.” Likewise, the British Foreign Office restricted second-division clerks from processing telegrams until 1911.

Pressures towards greater hierarchy also affected overseas legations. In 1909 the U.S. Department of State decreed that only the head of mission and first secretary were allowed to handle the main codebook used for decrypting secret telegrams. In France the foreign minister asked heads of mission to provide written justification for each telegram they sent.⁹ While in practice such regulations often proved unworkable, John Kenneth Galbraith, as U.S. ambassador to India, used language that he later recommended to his fellow chiefs of mission: “All ... communications ... go through me.” This would ensure that “you know fully what is going on and can act as necessary against that of which you disapprove, including vetoing the transmission itself.” Furthermore, telegraphy—unlike media capable of directly broadcasting to a large audience—operated from point to point. As a result, some people received information before others and became conduits for its diffusion.¹⁰

While the telegraph did not usually accelerate the pace of diplomatic life, one important exception exists—the decision to declare war, a decision that was too important to be left to foreign ministers. In such an instance, the telegraph could enormously hasten events by reducing the time necessary for the rulers of different states to communicate with one another.

By 1870, it was already observable that the telegraph had a huge impact on American diplomacy, especially through the use of the Atlantic cable. The telegraph, however, did have significant problems when being used in the area of diplomacy: expense, security, transmission errors, and the fear of using something new.

Expense was the first concern in the use of the telegraph. While messages sent overland were considered dear, the immense costs and lack of competition faced by the two transatlantic telegraph companies resulted in very high prices—more than five dollars per word in 1870. The State Department had good reason to be concerned about expenses since the diplomatic service of the United States was notoriously underfunded.^{[11](#)}

The issue of telegraphic cost came about when the Franco-Prussian War began in 1870. Ambassador Washburne had such doubts about incurring the cost of telegraphing Washington with the news of the war that he sent the message by boat, also in the same message asking Secretary of State Hamilton Fish for guidance on when to use the transatlantic cable. This lack of warning due to cost left Washington unprepared to deal with the consequences of the conflict. The Franco-Prussian War depressed government bonds on which U.S. credit rested, disrupted trade flows, threatened diplomatic entanglement as both sides sought American support, led to breaches of U.S. neutrality by both belligerents, and created significant new diplomatic obligations (e.g., the American responsibility for protecting German citizens trapped in Paris). While the war did not threaten any vital U.S. interests, it did pose important problems for which American officials might have been better prepared had they received earlier warning.^{[12](#)}

This desire to avoid spending money to send telegraphic messages led American diplomats to hope that journalists and businessmen would send important political news at their own expense over the Atlantic cable to America.^{[13](#)} This is a possible reason why the U.S. legation in Paris was remiss in reporting the coming of the Franco-Prussian War. When news of the French war declaration reached the U.S. government, it came via the Associated Press rather than by a governmental dispatch.^{[14](#)}

This frugality continued to prevail over the timely reporting of important information. On July 13, 1814, Frank Mallet, the American vice consul general in Budapest, predicted war between Austria-Hungary and Serbia. But Mallet faced a dilemma; his superiors would have likely chastised him for sending this information to Washington. The telegram would have been about 150 words and Mallet knew that the State Department considered long telegrams extravagant and an excessive strain on those charged with deciphering them. Since this was the case, Mallet sent a letter by steamer rather than a telegram. His warning arrived fourteen days later, on July 27, 1914; Austria-Hungary declared war on Serbia the next morning.^{[15](#)}

The telegraph's high prices resulted from the fact that their systems required skilled labor and an expensive infrastructure and, in turn, provided a scarce resource because, at first the lines could only carry one message at a time. The limited carrying capacity of telegraph lines allowed those who controlled the lines to ration access to them.



Austrian field telegraph station in Russian Poland, circa 1910–15 (Library of Congress).

Cost also became a factor in a different way. With the completion of the Atlantic cable in 1866, William Henry Seward, the U.S. secretary of state, sent a telegram whose high cost caused controversy. One reason that it was so expensive was that Seward, with an eye to increasing his popularity with the American electorate, sought to create the impression that he was capable of managing events from afar. He justified his long and expensive message by saying that he wanted his envoy to read it verbatim to Emperor Napoleon III. “For this reason,” Seward noted, “no word was omitted under any consideration of economy.”¹⁶ Although Seward implied that the cable destroyed the autonomy of the U.S. minister to France, in the end it did not since the minister decided not to deliver Seward’s telegram.

Another problem in the use of the telegraph by diplomats was that of security. Before the telegraph, foreign ministers gave their written messages to trusted couriers. Diplomatic pouches, envelopes, and elaborate wax seals provided additional protection from having their contents read. The telegram in this case offered less protection than giving the contents of the secret diplomatic dispatch to a telegraph clerk who was an unknown foreign national employed by a foreign government for transmission to one's country. The reason was that diplomats were forced to send telegrams through the state monopolies of their host countries and of those countries through which their messages travelled. This situation compelled foreign ministries to rely on encrypted messages in order to thwart the intelligence agencies of those countries through which the messages were sent. As a solution to the problem, beginning in 1867, the U.S. government gave its foreign ministries a cipher to be used in transmitting sensitive information over the Atlantic cable. Codes not only added security but also offered a means of shortening messages and saving money. In one historian's opinion, "the telegraph made cryptography what it is today."¹⁷

Garbled telegrams, caused by both human and mechanical errors, also limited the usefulness of the telegraph in diplomacy. This was not a problem when the message was sent unencrypted, because any mistakes were obvious. When encoded, however, errors became critical because, since they could not be read by the sending telegraph clerk, the mistakes went through. Additionally, since the encrypted messages were as brief as possible in order to save money, the error rate was far greater than it would have been using written diplomatic dispatches. After receiving a garbled message from the secretary of state on July 17, 1870, Hoffman noted, "I deciphered it with some difficulty, many letters in important words having been changed in the transmission." The same day, Hoffman received a second telegram from the same sender, which, "happily," was "not in cipher."¹⁸

Another garbled message from this period of time produced by human error in the system of diplomatic communications shows how serious these mistakes can be. The immediate causes of the Franco-Prussian War can be found in a mistake that the Prussian delegation in Madrid made when deciphering a telegram. The error, a substitution of the word "ninth" for the word "twenty-sixth," led to a delay in Bismarck's secret plan to place a Hohenzollern¹⁹ on the throne of Spain. During the delay, news of the plot reached the French government, precipitating the crisis that resulted in the destruction of Napoleon III's regime and the creation of the Second Empire in Germany.²⁰

The last problem involving the use of the telegraph in diplomacy was simply inertia. Even when one of its major drawbacks, the cost, ceased to be a factor, the diplomats were slow to use it. The cost of the

Atlantic cable dropped at an average rate of 15 percent per year for the first twenty years after its successful implementation. In 1866, a telegram between Washington and London cost ten dollars per word; by 1904, the price dropped to twenty cents per word. Despite this large price reduction, there was not a corresponding increase in usage among diplomats.²¹ This situation continued especially among American diplomats, who used the telegraph basically during emergencies until World War I. Before then the usual means of diplomatic communication was letters. The war became the impetus which pushed the diplomats into more frequent use of the telegram. During the war the State Department's expanded duties, larger budget, and more vigorous involvement in the competitive international arena induced it to utilize the telegraph with regularity. American diplomats began to employ it continuously. Although the State Department's use of the system declined after the peace negotiations, it remained higher than the prewar level.²²

There was also the obvious possibility that the diplomats avoided the use of the telegraph because it lessened their autonomy. Labor history has frequently explored worker sabotage of technologies that threatened their independence on the job. While there was no evidence that diplomats purposely avoided using the telegraph to maintain their freedom of movement, they had obvious incentives to cover up instances of their insubordination.²³

For another example of the use of the telegraph in diplomacy, it is useful to look at the British attempt to connect England with India via telegraphy. In this case the telegraph served two "empires," the British and the Ottoman. The reason was that in order to complete the landline between England and India, the British had to run the line the full 1800 miles through the Ottoman domains in Asia. For the British the telegraph acted not only to unite their empire, but also to enhance their political and commercial interests in the East. The Ottomans, on the other hand, exploited the advantages of electric communications to consolidate the control of their own empire.²⁴

Samuel Morse made two attempts to sell the telegraph to the Ottoman court, first in 1839 and then successfully in 1847. However, it was not until the Crimean War that the first line was actually built. The basic problem was the pashas.²⁵ Cyrus Hamlin, then a missionary, later the president of Robert College in Istanbul, observed in the Ottoman empire what was a probably the case in Europe, the question of autonomy. Here the pashas had united against the establishment of the telegraph: "They wanted no such tell-tale to report their doings every day, while in the distant interior."²⁶ Even when the telegraph was being tested in the sultan's court, the wires had been found to have been mysteriously cut,

possible by a pasha who wished the trial to fail. Since the pashas ruled arbitrarily in the distant provinces of the empire, the introduction of the telegraph was not in their interests. With the telegraph, the sultan's orders could be quickly conveyed to the governors and officials, who could be summoned to Istanbul or be replaced without warning. Furthermore, public complaints and petitions about the pashas could be communicated to the sultan directly.

With the outbreak of the Crimean War in 1853, Britain and France joined the empire in an effort to prevent Russia from expanding its territory into the Mediterranean. This alliance allowed the Ottomans to put aside their opposition to new innovations which would have prevented the acquisition of the telegraph, usually based on religious grounds, since religious law held that innovations useful to winning a war were justifiable.

With the conclusion of the Crimean War, the Ottoman empire joined Britain and France in the construction of telegraph lines across their territory. Even though the Ottoman interest in telegraphy had grown substantially since the beginning of the war, they needed the know-how that the British and French possessed and those nations needed the empire to provide poles, labor, and protection for the completed lines.

When it came to a contract between the three countries, however, the Ottomans, influenced by the French, opposed the whole design of the telegraph line because their capital, Baghdad, was not chosen as the terminus of the line. Such dissension was an ordinary occurrence: Britain and France often competed for concessions in the Ottoman empire, each hoping to expand its sphere of influence through these undertakings, while the empire sought a tactical balance between them.

In this case, however, the empire went further. Increasingly aware of the economic and political implications of telegraph links among their major towns and provinces and Baghdad, they stopped all further negotiations on any telegraph systems controlled by the British or the French. The Ottoman officials insisted on keeping "the telegraph towards India in their own hands."²⁷

The empire pushed its advantage as far as possible. While keeping overall control of the project, it agreed to employ British engineers and workmen that had been employed by the European and Indian Junction Telegraph Company²⁸ and to use the company's stock of supplies. It also offered to build the line with two wires, one to be retained by the Ottoman government for its own service, the other to

connect England with India. Diplomatically, Ali Pasha, the Ottoman foreign minister, explained the dual advantages of this project; on the one hand it would fulfill Britain's aim of direct communication with India, while at the same time it would render an immense service to the provinces of the Ottoman empire.

The British and Ottoman diplomats worked out an agreement. Not only would the line connect England to India, but would also be a basic way to introduce "Western civilization" to the East.²⁹ The British also agreed to pay the Ottoman government an annual subsidy to use the line when it was completed. The Ottomans were required to purchase all equipment necessary to build the line from English suppliers and to furnish the needed laborers. The planners, construction engineers, surveyors, linemen, and medical officers were supplied by the British.

The line was completed in January 1865, allowing the first uninterrupted telegraphic communication between India and Europe.

While the telegraph's impact on the relations between the United States and France and also on its construction the Ottoman empire during the nineteenth century are two examples of the telegraph's effect on diplomacy, consider these two quotes to bring into perspective not only immediacy, but also distance. First from a Tennessee congressman during the 1790s "Situated as the United States are, at a great distance from the transatlantic world ... what have we to do with the politics of Europe?"³⁰ Next, this assertion from a former American foreign diplomat, a hundred years later speaking of the telegraph, that it was among the new forces that "have brought foreign countries to our door and have carried us to theirs."³¹

Distance is what basically created foreign diplomats, since the head of a nation could not simultaneously rule at home and negotiate in a foreign country. This distance allowed the diplomat not only to convey messages back and forth between his host nation and his homeland but also to make decisions in the absence of the ruler of his country. Viscount Castlereagh, who had attempted to improve relations between Great Britain and the United States by revoking the "Orders in Council," noted, "The remoteness of America from the events passing in Europe mak[es] it of the utmost importance to the cultivation of a good understanding that an accredited minister, fully authorized to act for them in the many delicate cases that necessarily grow out of the present state of Europe and measures adopted by the Belligerents should be resident at this court."³²

Even when events overseas touched upon vital national interests, distance compelled governments to devolve power to diplomatic envoys. The mission of James Monroe to buy New Orleans from Napoleon

is illustrative. As President Thomas Jefferson said, no instructions could be “squared to fit” the circumstances that Monroe would be facing. Likewise during the crisis that preceded the Crimean War, Britain’s foreign secretary gave the British ambassador in Constantinople complete authority to declare war:

No later intelligence having since arrived, Her Majesty’s Government are uninformed whether the Sultan ... has actually declared war.... [It] is difficult to send you precise instructions upon a state of things so critical, but with respect to which so much uncertainty still prevails.

Her Majesty’s Government are far from intending to impose upon your Excellency any responsibility that they can properly take upon themselves, but having explained the reasons which render precise instructions impossible, they think it advisable to leave your Excellency and to Admiral Dundas, in concert with the French Ambassador and Admiral, to determine upon the best mode of giving effect to their views for the defense of the Ottoman dominions against direct aggression.³³

After completion of the telegraph line to India, colonial officials believed that they would now be able to better supervise their foreign proconsuls. Although the connection of England and India by telegraph enabled them to exercise much more power over England’s provinces than they formerly had, the reverse was true in these provinces. British writer George Orwell, who had spent time as a colonial official in Burma, remarked that telegraphy reduced “the one-time empire builders ... to the status of clerks, buried deeper and deeper under mounds of paper and red tape.”³⁴

During the time before telegraphic communication, governments wrote dispatches on the basis of old information and realized that their instructions would be even more dated when they finally reached their recipients. In the interim, many problems would have solved themselves. At times this made the entire exercise of writing instructions seem pointless, especially in a country that had few foreign interests. Thomas Jefferson, when serving as secretary of state under George Washington, is said to have observed that it was over two years since he had heard from the U.S. minister to Spain. If another year went by with no news, he planned to write to him.³⁵

The use of the telegraph, along with giving a nation better contact with its envoys, allowed the home government to claim the opposite, that there was no contact with an envoy, that the envoy acted on his own. This happened when governments needed to retreat from some position. This is known in

diplomatic circles as “plausible deniability.” In such cases the foreign minister takes the blame to protect their country when a policy goes wrong.

One such case involves President James Polk during the Oregon border dispute. When he was campaigning for office, he implied that if elected he would go to war against Great Britain unless the United States received the entire Oregon territory up to the fifty-fourth parallel (hence the famous slogan “Fifty-four forty or fight”). Once in office, however, Polk began to back off on his campaign pledge and go to the forty-ninth parallel when the negotiations stalled. Publicly, however, he still maintained that he would go to war if the British did not back down.

Louis McLane, the U.S. minister to Great Britain, followed Polk’s actual instructions and worked out an agreement with the British putting the line at the forty-ninth parallel. Polk sent the agreement to the Senate without supporting it, which created a feud between Polk and McLane. Regardless of who was more correct, Polk’s criticism of an agreement that his own agent had secured gained credibility because there were no written instructions that a telegraph would have provided.^{[36](#)}

Perhaps the greatest effect that the telegraph had on diplomacy was the loss of identity in the person of the foreign minister. At one time chiefs of mission exercised enormous individual power as actual policy makers; now they had become cogs in the machine. Consider this article from the *New York Times* in 1900:

It is a fact that [the diplomat] has become less of a statesman and more of a correspondent, an exponent of his master’s views, a go between, an instrument. He is allowed little individual action these days. Every move in his negotiations must be sanctioned by the Minister of Foreign Affairs, at home, every objection or demand coming from the other side is referred to this same august autocrat. There are no Kaunitzers or Talleyrands in these times of the fast mail and the telegraph, when instructions more particular can be so easily asked, and supplementary orders so quickly transmitted.^{[37](#)}

The effect of telegraphy on the individual diplomat varied greatly. In some cases, diplomats welcomed instantaneous communication with their foreign offices since it relieved them of the responsibility of on the spot decision making. Many diplomats, however, did not. A British envoy commented upon “this age of rapid communication, of what I would call the telegraphic demoralization of those who formerly had to act for themselves and are now content to be at the end of the wire.” A British colonial agent groused, “I might have been a great man, but for the telegraph.” Francis Bertie, who worked both in the British

Foreign Office and as a diplomat, also complained, “In Downing Street one can at least pull the wires, whereas an Ambassador is only a d . . . d marionette.” Many diplomats felt that electric telegraphy deprived their activities of value,³⁸ some to the point that they refused a position. In 1913 President Woodrow Wilson offered Richard Olney the post of ambassador to Great Britain. Olney declined the offer, partly because his experience as secretary of state during the Cleveland administration had convinced him that “the English Ambassadorship is a show place—all the real work being done in Washington.” Olney also noted: “An ambassador is nobody in these days. He sits at the end of a cable and does what he is told.”³⁹

Another use of the diplomatic telegraph in giving a nation’s rulers a choice was whether to deal directly with a foreign country or use their envoy. Consider this from a British diplomat about the effect of the telegraph on this choice:

When a crises of a certain magnitude occur, Foreign Ministers ignore their Ambassadors and correspond over their heads direct with one another.... The system is hard on the Ambassadors, diminishes their stature and destroys the relics of such of their initiative as has been left them by the telegraphic tyranny under which they habitually live. It may, indeed, be necessary in order to gain great ends. But if it is, it only goes to prove that in grave issues the diplomatic machinery to which we have been so long accustomed, is antiquated, and, given the modern facilities for quick communications between actual rulers, ineffective.⁴⁰

Two factors—crisis induced stress and the desire to act quickly—made political leaders likely to circumvent their envoys if they believed that circumstances warranted that course of action. The desire to deal directly with a foreign nation predated the telegraph; now, however, they could communicate in real time.⁴¹

Finley Peter Dunne’s Mr. Dooley also had an opinion on diplomats and the telegraph: “In odher to keep up with what is goin’ on th’ Ambassadure has to get out arly an’ buy th’ mornin’ papers. Th’ first thing he knows about a war that’s broke out between th’ two counthries is whin he goes around to call on th’ King an’ a senthry jabs him with a baynit.”⁴²

Since the use of telegraphy in diplomacy tended to concentrate power in the hands of a nation’s bureaucracy and to a lesser extent in the control of those who had the power before the telegraph’s

existence, its use became something to be avoided by some diplomats. Three examples of legates resisting the constraints of the telegraph are the British envoy to Constantinople, Lord Stratford de Redcliffe; the French ambassador to St. Petersburg, Maurice Paleologue; and Baron Wilhelm von Schoen, Germany's ambassador to Paris.

Lord Stratford de Redcliffe was described as “the last diplomat to hold the issue of war or peace in his hands.” He believed the telegraphic communications to be “subject ... by their very nature, to the risk of erroneous information, or premature instructions.” Also, telegrams were “liable to frequent mistakes in the transmission” and were sometimes so concise (because of cost) that diplomats were forced to rely upon their own judgment.⁴³ Since this was the case, it was Stratford's opinion that a diplomat was forced to use “superior judgment” (such as his own) to decide whether or not a particular message from the foreign office was to be heeded.

Some diplomats agreed with Stratford that the cost factor prevented London from micromanaging foreign affairs. In 1861, Lord John Russell averred that diplomats had more autonomy because of short, concise telegrams than they would have had from long, detailed written instructions. Sir John Tilley, chief clerk of the Foreign Office during the First World War, agreed: “It is certainly the case that an Ambassador may be a good deal at sea as to the reason for his instructions and the spirit in which they are issued, and yet may not feel that he can delay action till he has obtained clearer explanation.”⁴⁴ The basic problem was that telegrams carried small amounts of information very quickly, as against a letter which carried all the information slowly. The onus was on the countries' Foreign Office; if the telegram stated the intention of the message clearly, all was well, if not, the power of decision went to the diplomat.

Maurice Paleologue was another example of a diplomat who wished to act on his own, ignoring instructions from the foreign ministry. In 1914 he was appointed ambassador to St. Petersburg. His problem was that he had a great admiration for Russia and at the same time was deeply pessimistic about Germany's intentions. Because he believed that Germany would attack France before the Russians could mobilize,⁴⁵ he prodded the Russians to attack Germany.

What transpired subsequently became a prime example of a self-reliant diplomat who believed in the “great man” theory of history even in the age of instant communication brought about by the telegraph. Acting independently, Paleologue assured Russia that it could count on unqualified French support in any pledges that it made to Serbia. Secondly, he did not inform Paris of Russian mobilization. His

motives were to ensure that the war which he saw as inevitable should come sooner rather than later, so that the French and Russian armies would not be at a disadvantage fighting the Germans without the support of the other.

On July 31, 1914, French Prime Minister Rene Viviani, unaware of Paleologue's actions and attempting to avoid war, sent a telegram to Paleologue which ended, "As I have already informed you, I have no doubt that the Imperial [Russian] government, in the greater interest of peace, will avoid, for its part, anything which could begin the crisis." However, by this time Russian mobilization had already begun and war was inevitable. Because of their ignorance of events, the French leaders had no opportunity to influence the decisions made by Russia, decisions that would have far-reaching effects on their own country.^{[46](#)}

On August 3, 1914, Germany's ambassador to France, Baron Wilhelm von Schoen, presented a German declaration of war to the French prime minister. The German government had instructed Schoen to tell the French that the reason for the declaration was that French aviators had committed hostile acts over German territory and that French ground troops had crossed the border into Germany. Schoen only discussed the air strikes with the French, claiming that the part of the telegram that discussed the border incursions was garbled. Schoen later wrote that, "the telegram was so mutilated that, in spite of every effort, only fragments of it could be deciphered." He added, "As I knew from other sources that we felt bound to declare war in consequence of a French air attack on Nuremberg, I had to make up my mind to fall back on the little that could be clearly understood from the telegram, to justify the declaration of war."^{[47](#)}

Why had Schoen falsely claimed that the telegram conveying the German declaration of war had been garbled? Was it to spare himself the shame of presenting a dishonorable war declaration? In any case, Schoen's behavior, like that of Stratford and Paleologue, demonstrates a tactic that diplomats could use to escape oversight from their foreign offices, because of the use of the telegraph.^{[48](#)}

During the nineteenth century, most nations attempted to concentrate decision making at the top and the telegraph fit into this reasoning. Centralization through the use of the telegraph, however, had a downside, which was pointed out by a historian of the British Colonial Office: "Questions great and small, which formerly were decided on the spot, were now thrown upon the Home Government, not with the full information of a dispatch, but with the elliptical curtness of cipher telegrams."^{[49](#)}

The drafting and revision of telegrams took time. Diplomats tended to choose every word in a telegram with great care because of the need for brevity (due to cost concerns) and the dangers of ambiguity. Through the period of the First World War, foreign ministry clerks manually coded and decoded messages, a laborious process that could significantly delay the transmission of messages. In the case of a message of particular importance, a foreign ministry official might even cable a warning to a distant diplomat, such as, “You will receive a very important message as soon as it can be put into cipher.” The seriousness of cipher related holdups led foreign ministries to send uncoded messages when speed was important and secrecy was not.⁵⁰

Other problems impeded speed in the sending of messages. First was the fact that if the message was travelling a long distance, it would have to be retransmitted at various relay stations in order to boost the signal. As an example, a cablegram from London to Australia in 1900 took six hours to complete the distance. Also, telegraph companies often repeated encoded telegrams, since such messages were incomprehensible to the telegraphers and therefore prone to garbling. They might also recapitulate transmissions when they had reason to believe that an error had occurred. The manager of a telegraph company warned the German embassy in Washington, “Due allowance should be made for the time required for transmission and repetition.” Even as late as 1998, when the British Foreign Office announced that it would stop using telegraphy, newspapers noted that a telegram not marked “urgent” typically required twenty-four hours to reach the intended minister.⁵¹

Of all the diplomatic telegrams that have ever been delivered late, the most famous is probably the final message from the Japanese government to the American secretary of state, Cordell Hull, breaking off negotiations before the attack on Pearl Harbor on December 7, 1941. Because the telegram reached Hull the day after the attack, it became a symbol of Japanese perfidy and stimulated the American war effort.

While it is not known precisely why the telegram was delivered late, there were a number of factors involved: first, the telegram was not marked urgent; second, the Japanese used decoding machines to decipher secret messages and two of their machines had been destroyed, slowing the decoding process; and third, the message arrived with missing and garbled words. In the age of the telegraph, communication delays were always possible and sometimes probable.

Even the perception of the telegraph’s speed caused problems for diplomats. Consider these words in 1864 from Charles Francis Adams, the American envoy to Britain:

Although entirely friendly to [the cable] scheme, I must confess I am not very anxious it should be carried out immediately. It is a very great object no doubt to bring the two countries together, but I cannot help arguing with myself that if, with the two countries three thousand miles apart, I get so many dispatches per week that I can with difficulty attend to them all satisfactorily, what would be my fate if the cable succeeds, and I had to receive and answer them every day? Therefore, I shall wish success to the Submarine Telegraph between Europe and America, but [may it] happen with just about as little delay as may bring it to the moment when I hope to be back in my native country.⁵²

Another diplomat, Edmund Hammond, the permanent undersecretary at the British Foreign Office, spoke of another consequence of the telegraph's speed: "I dislike the telegraph very much. In the first place nothing is explained by it, it tempts hasty decision." Concise telegrams often conveyed enough data to induce panic without imparting the information necessary to provide understanding.⁵³ An editorial in the London *Spectator* made the same point:

It is rumour rather than intelligence which is hurried so breathlessly across continents and seas.... The constant diffusion of statements in snippets, the constant excitements of feeling unjustified by fact, the constant formation of hasty or erroneous opinions, must in the end, one would think, deteriorate the intelligence of all to whom the telegraph appeals.... Is it conceivable that statesmen, informed of all they know through such a medium, with its inevitable hurries, its inherent necessity for over-compression, its unavoidable reticence's, should ever know really *know* even events, should ever be wisely counselled, should ever be internally urged to reflection, as they were under the old *regime*?⁵⁴

The use of the diplomatic telegram gave rise to a new form of espionage—code breaking. Instead of relying entirely on spies, countries also attempted to collect information from the messages being sent from the field to the home ministries. The ease with which a code breaker could read an encoded message depended on the code maker. This was a difficult and time consuming endeavor because the cipher had to be: cost-effective, concise, secretive, reliable, easy to use, and yet difficult to break. If this was not the case then a diplomatic telegram message became, in the words of the secretary of the French Atlantic Telegraph Company, an "open letter." This was especially true when a nation's telegraph system had been nationalized, which was the case in every major power except the United States. As a result, diplomats in foreign countries were wise to assume that their telegraphic messages were being read by their host's intelligence services. Thomas F. Bayard, the U.S. secretary of state, warned, "It is

generally understood that some governments, especially those whose telegraphs are under the charge of the central administration, spare no effort to decipher the secret messages of foreign representatives.” A former Austrian code officer, describing the years before the First World War, noted, “Our telegraphers, like those of other governments, were instructed to send us a copy of every cipher dispatch that passed over their wires.” During the First World War, the Vatican was the most striking example of a diplomatic power vulnerable to intercepted messages: once Italy entered the war, at least one of the belligerents, and frequently more, could obtain every telegram from the papacy.⁵⁵

Looking at diplomatic telegraphy from the viewpoint of efficiency, there is no doubt that there were many advantages. Faster communication which facilitated day-to-day diplomacy allowed rapid answers to incoming questions and timely solutions to sudden problems. The telegraph offered unprecedented capabilities to its users, as remarkable for its time as those afforded in recent years by other new means of conveying information such as the Internet. It promised the nearly instantaneous transmission of complex messages over enormous distances, freeing information from dependence on human carriers. Even more than the steam engine, transoceanic telegraphy marked a liberation from the influence of weather conditions that imposed so much uncertainty on communication by sailing ship. Yet diplomats, from code clerks to ambassadors, did not always feel that they had benefited by its use. Many complained about a technology that reduced their authority, lessened their control over their work environment, and degraded their working conditions.

Nevertheless, this revolutionary technology did not produce a revolution. The Atlantic cable had in fact gradual consequences for diplomacy, since, despite the influence of telegraphy, ship-carried diplomatic pouches continued to play a predominant role in American foreign policy until the First World War.

Moreover, as the historian Svante Lindqvist suggests, older technological systems embody values that influence “the thoughts and social actions” of later periods.⁵⁶ This may explain the lag between the creation of a technical capability, in this case the telegraph, and its acceptance by foreign ministries. Because of this disconnect, the United States and other nations maintained diplomatic practices no longer adequate in a rapidly changing world; in other words, their adaption to the telegraph lagged dangerously behind their adoption of it.⁵⁷